The Effects of Globalization and Internationalization on Higher Education in the United States

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Abstract

This article examines the effects of globalization and internationalization on higher education in the United States, with particular attention to their economic, political, and moral implications. While globalization emphasizes transnational knowledge exchange and human interaction, internationalization increasingly frames higher education as a market-driven enterprise. The article argues that internationalization—rather than globalization—has become the dominant force shaping U.S. higher education, resulting in the commodification of education, structural inequalities for international students, and growing tension between market logic and education's moral status as a human right.

Introduction

In an era of accelerating global interconnectedness, higher education occupies an increasingly ambivalent position between moral ideal and economic instrument. Universities are celebrated as spaces of intercultural exchange and global knowledge circulation, yet they are simultaneously embedded in competitive market systems that prioritize revenue generation and institutional ranking.[1]

The expanding presence of international students in U.S. higher education exemplifies this tension. On the one hand, international student mobility reflects the promise of globalization through intellectual exchange and cultural encounter. On the other hand, international students are frequently positioned as revenue sources, subject to higher tuition rates, restrictive visa

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[1] Manuel Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society,* 2nd ed. (Oxford: Wiley-Blackwell, 2010); Robin Shields, *Globalization and International Education* (London: Bloomsbury, 2013).

regimes, and limited institutional protection.[2] This contradiction raises a central question: can higher education reconcile market pressures with its ethical responsibility to function as a public good?

Globalization, Internationalization, and Higher Education

Although often used interchangeably, globalization and internationalization represent fundamentally different processes. Globalization refers to the intensification of social relations, information flows, and cultural interaction across national boundaries, grounded primarily in human exchange. Internationalization, by contrast, denotes structured economic and political relationships among institutions and states, often driven by competition, profitability, and strategic interest.[3]

In higher education, internationalization has increasingly transformed learning into an exportable commodity. Universities compete globally for tuition-paying students, research funding, and prestige, aligning institutional priorities with market logic rather than educational ideals.[4] As a result, the ethical foundations of higher education are increasingly subordinated to economic imperatives.

Technology, Information, and the Knowledge Economy

Advances in digital communication and information technology have accelerated the globalization of knowledge and reshaped higher education's institutional role. Scholars of political economy argue that contemporary capitalism increasingly operates as a "knowledge economy," in which education functions as a form of human capital investment.[5]

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[2] Institute of International Education, "Economic Impact of International Students," accessed December 15, 2018; NAFSA, "International Student Economic Value Tool," accessed December 15, 2018.

[3] On the conceptual distinction between globalization and internationalization, see Rodrigo G. Britez and Michael A. Peters, "Internationalization and the Cosmopolitical University," *Geopolitics, History, and International Relations*2, no. 1 (2010): 34–49.

[4] Paule Chau, "Online Education as Commodity," *Journal of Computing in Higher Education* 22, no. 3 (2010): 177–191; Katharine B. Silbaugh, "Testing as Commodification," *Washington Journal of Law and Policy* 35 (2011): 309–332.

[5] John Black, Nigar Hashimzade, and Gareth Myles, "International Economics," in *A Dictionary of Economics* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017).

Within this framework, students are framed as economic actors, universities as service providers, and education as a pathway to labor-market competitiveness. This shift has contributed to declining public funding, rising tuition costs, and growing student debt. International students, who often pay significantly higher tuition and face employment restrictions, have become especially central to university revenue models.[6]

International Students and the Post-9/11 Context

International student mobility has long played a critical role in U.S. higher education and global academic influence. Immigration reforms in the mid-twentieth century facilitated increased diversity among international students and contributed to transnational knowledge circulation rather than simple "brain drain."[7]

The events of September 11, 2001, however, marked a significant turning point. In the post-9/11 era, international students—particularly those from Muslim-majority countries—were increasingly subjected to suspicion, surveillance, and restrictive visa policies.[8] Although international students remained economically desirable, they became politically vulnerable, reinforcing the contradictions of internationalization.[9]

Education as a Human Right

At the core of these developments lies a fundamental ethical question: is higher education a privilege or a human right? Article 26 of the *Universal Declaration of Human Rights* affirms education as essential to human dignity and social participation.[10] Legal and philosophical

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[6] Michael Mitchell, Michael Leachman, and Kathleen Masterson, "Funding Down, Tuition Up," report, Center on Budget and Policy Priorities, August 15, 2016.

[7] Frédéric Docquier and Hillel Rapoport, "Globalization, Brain Drain, and Development," *Journal of Economic Literature* 50, no. 3 (2012): 681–730; Margaret O'Mara, "The Uses of Foreign Students," *Social Science History* 36, no. 4 (2012): 583–615.

[8] Karin A. C. Johnson, "9/11 and International Student Visa Issuance," *Journal of Studies in International Education* 22, no. 5 (2018): 393–413.

[9] Ameena K. Jandali, "Muslim Students in Post-9/11 Classrooms," *Education Digest* (2013): 21–24; Brent Neiman and Phillip Swagel, "The Impacts of Post-9/11 Visa Policies," *Journal of International Economics* 78 (2009): 86–99.

[10] United Nations, *Universal Declaration of Human Rights*, art. 26.

scholarship further argues that denying access to education on the basis of wealth, nationality, or immigration status undermines fundamental principles of justice.

In the United States, access to higher education remains deeply stratified by income and citizenship. Elite institutions disproportionately enroll students from the highest income brackets, while international students face structural barriers that conflict with the moral status of education as a universal right.[11]

Nationalism and Exclusion

Nationalist discourse further complicates the ethical landscape of international education. Civic nationalism, grounded in shared political values, can support inclusive institutions. Ethnic nationalism, by contrast, defines belonging through ancestry or culture and often legitimizes exclusionary policies.[12]

In recent decades, ethnic nationalist rhetoric has periodically framed international students as economic or security threats. Such narratives obscure structural inequality and undermine education's role in fostering critical thought, intercultural understanding, and democratic citizenship.

Conclusion

This article has argued that internationalization—rather than globalization—has become the dominant force shaping higher education in the United States. Driven by market logic, internationalization has commodified education, intensified inequality, and eroded higher education's ethical foundations, particularly for international students.

Globalization and internationalization need not be mutually exclusive. When guided by ethical commitments rather than economic imperatives alone, globalization can support inclusive academic communities and transnational knowledge exchange. The future of higher education depends on whether institutions are willing to reaffirm education not merely as an economic investment, but as a shared human good.

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[11] Heidi R. Gilchrist, "Higher Education as a Human Right," *Washington University Global Law Review* 17 (2018): 645–676.

[12] David Miller, "The Ethnic Significance of Nationality," in *Global Ethics*, ed. Thomas Pogge and Keith Horton (St. Paul, MN: Paragon House, 2008), 235–254; Bernard Yack, "The Myth of Civic Nationalism," *Vigile*, July1, 2000.

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